

Competency Profile For Pharmacy Technicians

The Pharmacy Technician Competency Profile was developed by using three assumptions about the pharmacy technician's role and eight expectations of pharmacy technicians who will practise within the proposed expanded role.

ASSUMPTIONS

Upon registration by the Ontario College of Pharmacists, pharmacy technicians will:

1. Act within the established parameters of the role as outlined by the College and will comply with the College's professional standards, practice expectations, and, where established, will follow applicable policies and procedures of the College and/or the workplace
2. Exercise professional judgment related to the technical and distributive aspects of dispensing in the expanded role
3. Recognize practice situations in which decisions and actions must involve the pharmacist; those in which consultation with the pharmacist or, where appropriate, with other registered pharmacy technicians can occur; and those decisions and actions that can be undertaken independently. Pharmacy technicians exercise critical-thinking, problem-solving, decision-making, and judgement to differentiate among these three contexts

EXPECTATIONS

Pharmacy technicians registered with the College will be personally responsible and professionally accountable to practise knowledgeably, safely, and competently to support the best interests of patients by:

1. Knowing and complying with all provincial and federal legislation and regulations relevant to pharmacy and their role as pharmacy technicians within pharmacy practice; with professional standards and practice expectations and guidelines; and with policies and procedures where established
2. Using critical-thinking and decision-making skills appropriate to the pharmacy technician role
Critical thinking is the foundation for making safe, patient care-focused decisions. It is the process of integrating one's relevant theory, experience, and observations, as well as recognizing similarities/differences/changes in context and situations into a whole. Critical thinking by pharmacy technicians should be consistent with the technician's level of education, training, experience, and scope of practice. Decision-making by technicians should involve the ability to question effectively, to seek out guidance and information, to incorporate information, and to select those options, from a variety of options, that result in safe and competent technician practice
3. Performing, safely and competently, the technical and distributive aspects of dispensing as permitted by law, professional standards, practice guidelines and expectations, and applicable policies and procedures

4. Demonstrating the judgement required to identify the need for pharmacist intervention and to notify the pharmacist of this need
5. Demonstrating the judgement and safe practices required to: receive and enter written, orally, and electronically transmitted new and repeat prescriptions; differentiate changes to patient profiles or health records, and notifying the pharmacist when these occur; prepare, compound, and check pharmaceutical products; and collaborate with the pharmacist in their release
6. Acting within the limits of the expanded professional role and personal knowledge and skills
While it is anticipated that as pharmacy technicians mature within their professional roles they will demonstrate quality improvement related to increased knowledge and experience in the expanded role: All registered pharmacy technicians will be held accountable to the public to not exceed the legislated parameters of their roles
7. Behaving in a professional manner; acting within an ethical framework at all times; and demonstrating personal integrity
8. Engaging in quality assurance activities including a commitment to life-long learning; and identification, implementation, and evaluation of learning plans, activities, and opportunities

Furthermore, entry-level pharmacy technicians in the expanded role will:

1. Be registered by the Ontario College of Pharmacists, thus entitled to the rights of, and be expected to comply with the responsibilities of, a self-regulating profession; and
2. Possess the essential knowledge, skills, values, and judgement required to demonstrate these *Competencies*
However, entry-level pharmacy technicians may have differing experiences as they enter the role —

given the variety of environments in which learning and practice occur. Therefore, the College will engage in a registration process that will ensure consistent benchmarks for entry. The pharmacy technician must be successful in this registration examination to apply for registration.

SUMMARY

We recognize that any expansion into the technical and distributive aspects of dispensing (outlined in this *Profile*) will require the College to support this new role through appropriate legislation and regulation, creation of a registered class, and regulatory infrastructure that will ensure consistent benchmarks for technicians' entry into, and continuance in, the expanded role.

The College has pursued a regulated health profession status for technicians under two principles. First, expanding the role would require changes to legislation to permit technicians to receive oral prescriptions, to check the preparation of a pharmaceutical product, and to transfer prescriptions. The second principle was based on the belief that all technicians performing the expanded role should be accountable to the public for their performance.

In considering the impact of professional accountability on public welfare, the College also recognized that an expanded role would be articulated in a legislative and regulatory framework and would, therefore, result in the creation of a second registrant group at the College.

This *Profile* offers a clear picture of the requirements of the expanded technician role within the Ontario healthcare system and goes beyond the current definition and framework of the voluntary certification program. Enabled by legislation and supported by complementary professional standards, practice expectations, and regulatory framework, the *Profile* will support optimal pharmaceutical care and pharmacy services to the public.



COMPETENCY: PRACTICE IN A PROFESSIONAL MANNER THAT IS WITHIN LEGAL REQUIREMENTS AND AN ETHICAL FRAMEWORK

A1.0 COMPETENCY UNIT

Comply with legal requirements; demonstrate professional integrity; and act ethically.

COMPETENCY ELEMENTS

A1.1 Use critical-thinking skills in all situations

A1.2 Comply with federal and provincial legislation, professional standards, ethical guidelines, practice expectations, and established policies and procedures

Keep current with, apply knowledge of, and work within relevant legislation, regulations, policies and procedures

- i) Recognize the right, role, and responsibility of regulatory bodies to establish and monitor professional standards, ethical guidelines, and practice expectations
- ii) Keep current with, and work within, professional standards, practice expectations, ethical guidelines, and, where provided, established policies and procedures

A1.3 Demonstrate professional and personal integrity

- i) Accept responsibility for own decisions and actions
- ii) Practise within the limits of professional role and personal knowledge and expertise
- iii) Integrate professional knowledge, skills, values, and judgement into practice
- iv) Respect the rights, roles, and responsibilities of the patient, the patient's agent, the pharmacy team, healthcare providers, and others
- v) Act as a role model and mentor
- vi) Respect the roles and collaborate with members of the pharmacy team
- vii) Behave professionally
- viii) Maintain confidentiality

A1.4 Take responsibility for own professional development

- i) Reflect upon own practice to identify learning needs
- ii) Develop, implement, evaluate, and update learning plans to gain knowledge and experience and to maintain and improve practice
- iii) Seek out and incorporate into practice, information, guidance and constructive feedback from the pharmacist and/or, if required, from other healthcare professionals
- iv) Demonstrate evidence-based knowledge, appropriate to their role
- v) Commit to life-long learning

A1.5 Apply ethical principles to practice

- i) Ensure that the professional role, responsibilities, actions, and behaviours are carried out in the best interest of the patient and the public
- ii) Reflect on personal values and attitudes and examine their influence on interactions with the patient, the patient's agents, members of the pharmacy team, healthcare providers
- iii) Respect diversity

- A1.6 Protect patient rights to quality care, dignity, privacy, and confidentiality**
- A1.7 Understand and promote the pharmacy team's role in promoting patients' health and wellness**
- A1.8 Contribute to team problem-solving, decision-making, and collaboration by developing effective working relationships, using team-building strategies, communicating effectively, and by supporting members of the pharmacy team**

B

COMPETENCY: RECEIVE A PRESCRIPTION

Pharmacy technicians, as part of the pharmacy team, use their knowledge and skills and follow applicable policies and procedures to:

B1.0 COMPETENCY UNIT

Receive a new prescription, or a request to renew a prescription, from a patient or patient's agent.

COMPETENCY ELEMENTS

B1.1 Gather information to create and maintain a patient profile or health record

- i) Obtain patient consent where required
- ii) Differentiate when there are changes in the drug and dosage, the patient profile or health record and, where provided, the diagnosis or medical condition; and notify the pharmacist
- iii) Update demographic and prescription data
- iv) Use paper-based, electronic, and other resources to locate and select information

B1.2 Check authenticity of the prescription

- i) Determine whether the prescription meets all legal requirements, and, where it does not, notify the pharmacist, and follow up using applicable policies, effective communication, and discretion
- ii) Use healthcare provider lists, where available, to determine current status of prescriber's privileges

B1.3 Verify accuracy and completeness of the demographic and prescription data

- i) Check the demographic and prescription data for accuracy and completeness
- ii) Review the prescription for clarity of abbreviations, medical terminology, drug names, dosage forms, strengths, availability, schedule, route, and related information
- iii) Notify the pharmacist regarding known allergies, therapeutic considerations, and/or discrepancies

B2.0 COMPETENCY UNIT

Receive a new or repeat prescription from a healthcare provider.

COMPETENCY ELEMENTS

B2.1 Receive an oral prescription

- i) Use effective communication skills, and where available, established communication policies, procedures, or guidelines when receiving an oral prescription
- ii) Verify demographic and prescription data with the healthcare provider
- iii) Refer therapeutic questions to the pharmacist

- iv) Transcribe an orally transmitted prescription by:
 - Using appropriate format, abbreviations, drug names, dosage forms, strengths, availability, schedule, route, and related information
 - Checking that the transcribed demographic and prescription data are accurate and complete

B2.2 Gather information to create and maintain the patient profile or health record

- i) Differentiate when there are changes in the drug and dosage, the patient profile or health record, and, where provided, the diagnosis or medical condition; and notify the pharmacist
- ii) Update demographic and prescription data
- iii) Use paper-based, electronic, and other resources to locate and select information

B2.3 Check for authenticity of orally and electronically transmitted prescriptions

- i) Determine whether the prescription meets all legal requirements: when it does not, notify the pharmacist and follow up by using applicable policies, effective communication, and discretion
- ii) Use healthcare provider lists, where available, to determine current status of prescriber's privileges

B2.4 Verify accuracy and completeness of orally and electronically transmitted demographic and prescription data

- i) Notify the pharmacist on known allergies, therapeutic considerations, and/or discrepancies
- ii) Check the demographic and prescription data for accuracy and completeness
- iii) Review the prescription for clarity on: abbreviations, medical terminology, drug names, dosage forms, strengths, availability, schedule, route, and other related information

B3.0 COMPETENCY UNIT

Transfer/copy a prescription in compliance with relevant legislation and established policies and procedures.

COMPETENCY ELEMENTS

B3.1 Transfer a prescription to another pharmacy

- i) Confirm that the patient or the patient's agent has approved/requested the transfer
- ii) Ensure accuracy and completeness before transferring a prescription
- iii) Complete required documentation

B3.2 Receive a transfer or copy of a prescription from another pharmacy

- i) Receive/transcribe the prescription, gather information, verify accuracy and completeness of the demographic and prescription data, and check for authenticity
- ii) Complete required documentation

B3.3 Provide a copy of a prescription to an authorized recipient

- i) Ensure accuracy and completeness of demographic and prescription data
- ii) Complete required documentation



COMPETENCY: ENTER A PRESCRIPTION

Pharmacy technicians, as part of the pharmacy team, use their knowledge and skills and follow applicable policies and procedures to:

C1.0 COMPETENCY UNIT

Enter a prescription as part of the processes used to prepare a pharmaceutical product for release and to keep records.

COMPETENCY ELEMENTS

C1.1 Enter and update demographic information in the patient profile or health record while ensuring privacy and confidentiality

- i) Verify accuracy and completeness of demographic information with the patient, the patient's agent, or the patient's healthcare provider

C1.2 Enter prescription data into the patient profile or health record

- i) Confirm accuracy, completeness, and authenticity of the prescription data and notes
- ii) Use correct format, terminology, abbreviations, and symbols
- iii) Associate drug names and classifications with common health conditions

C1.3 Notify the pharmacist of any alerts or therapeutic issues

- i) Differentiate when there are changes in the drug and dosage, the patient profile or health record, and, where provided, the diagnosis or medical condition
- ii) Review the patient profile or health record for alerts
- iii) Review the patient notes for patient preferences
- iv) Contact the patient or patient's agent to provide or retrieve relevant information or instructions
- v) Review current patient profile or health record to note duplicate therapies and active prescriptions on file
- vi) Notify the pharmacist of any changes and compliance issues

C1.4 Enter the pharmaceutical product/compound that meets the requirements of the prescription

- i) Determine patient preferences
- ii) Apply knowledge about available forms of the pharmaceutical product
- iii) Apply knowledge of third-party insurance plan coverage

C1.5 Verify that the entry of the demographic and prescription data is accurate and complete

- i) Compare demographic and prescription data entered into the record against information contained in the written prescription received, the electronically transmitted prescription, or the transcribed oral prescription



COMPETENCY: PREPARE A PHARMACEUTICAL PRODUCT FOR RELEASE IN COLLABORATION WITH THE PHARMACIST

Pharmacy technicians, as part of the pharmacy team, use their knowledge and skills and follow applicable policies and procedures to:

D1.0 COMPETENCY UNIT

Confirm that the pharmacist has had the opportunity to review the prescription and the patient profile or health record prior to the release of the pharmaceutical product.

D2.0 COMPETENCY UNIT

Prepare/compound a pharmaceutical product for release in collaboration with the pharmacist.

COMPETENCY ELEMENTS

D2.1 Obtain a pharmaceutical product that meets the requirements for the prescription

- i) Confirm availability of the product
- ii) Locate alternate sources when required

D2.2 Prepare/compound a sterile pharmaceutical product

- i) Follow approved formulation instructions
- ii) Select the needed product(s) and check the expiry date(s)
- iii) Calculate, convert, and document the results of dosage calculations and extemporaneous weights and volumes
- iv) Verify calculations with a second member of the pharmacy team who is registered
- v) Verify accuracy and appropriateness of ingredients and quantities including weights and volumes; and document
- vi) Select equipment
- vii) Follow aseptic technique

D2.3 Prepare a non-sterile compound, a pre-packaged pharmaceutical product, or a reconstituted pharmaceutical product

- i) Follow approved formulation instructions
- ii) Select the needed product(s) and check the expiry date(s)
- iii) Verify dosage calculations, weights and volumes, and, where necessary, confirm these with a second member of the pharmacy team who is registered and document the results.
- iv) Count, measure, or weigh the pharmaceutical product or products
- v) Follow clean technique

D2.4 Label the pharmaceutical product

- i) Select the appropriate container for the pharmaceutical product
- ii) Affix the appropriate label(s) to the pharmaceutical product or container
- iii) Provide appropriate patient information materials when specified by the pharmacist

D2.5 Perform quality control/assurance procedures**D3.0 COMPETENCY UNIT**

Verify the accuracy and completeness of a pharmaceutical product prepared for release.

COMPETENCY ELEMENTS**D3.1 Check the accuracy and completeness of the pharmaceutical product.**

- i) Ensure that the demographic and prescription data are correct and complete
- ii) Confirm that the:
 - Correct pharmaceutical product is being dispensed
 - Pharmaceutical product is correctly labelled, including appropriate auxiliary labels
 - Appropriate patient information materials have been provided
- iii) Confirm that the pharmaceutical product has been checked and signed off by a registered pharmacist, pharmacy intern, registered pharmacy technician *

*** Explanation**

To support public safety:

- (a) The registered pharmacy technician shall be permitted to check pharmaceutical products prepared by another registered pharmacy technician or by unregistered pharmacy personnel
- (b) The registered pharmacy technician, having prepared a pharmaceutical product, shall have it checked by a registered pharmacist, pharmacy intern or another registered pharmacy technician

D3.2 Complete required records and documentation.**D4.0 COMPETENCY UNIT**

Collaborate with the pharmacist in the release of the pharmaceutical product to the correct patient or patient's agent.

COMPETENCY ELEMENTS**D4.1 Confirm that the patient or the patient's agent has received or has been offered counselling by the pharmacist**

COMPETENCY : PERFORM DISTRIBUTIVE AND QUALITY ASSURANCE FUNCTIONS TO ENSURE THE PATIENT RECEIVES QUALITY PHARMACEUTICAL PRODUCTS

Pharmacy technicians, as part of the pharmacy team, use their knowledge and skills and follow applicable policies and procedures to:

E1. 0 COMPETENCY UNIT

Participate in distributive and quality assurance functions.

COMPETENCY ELEMENTS**E1.1 Contribute to optimal patient care and pharmacy services**

- i) Use critical-thinking, problem-solving, and decision-making skills to support effective and efficient patient care and pharmacy services

- ii) Develop effective working relationships with members of the pharmacy team
- iii) Provide constructive feedback on opportunities that could lead to increased effectiveness and efficiency of pharmacy services
- iv) Work with pharmacy management to identify staffing requirements, schedule personnel, determine and coordinate tasks, prioritize and organize pharmacy services, and develop operational policies
- v) Work together with members of the team to determine workflow, monitor progress of workflow, and identify and resolve barriers and challenges to optimal workflow
- vi) Use time management skills to prioritize workload demands, establish and work within realistic time frames, and evaluate and modify work patterns
- vii) Select technology that is appropriate to the task and use correctly
- viii) Follow guidelines for safe and correct use of automated medication storage distribution devices
- ix) Comply with health and safety legislation and workplace policies and procedures
- x) Address patient and colleague safety by ensuring a clean and accessible work area following infection control procedures, exercising caution related to workplace hazards, and making certain that high-risk activities are performed safely

E1.2 Apply knowledge of inventory management to contribute to optimal patient care and pharmacy services

E1.3 Follow procedures for the proper storage, handling, preparation, distribution, removal, and disposal of drugs

E1.4 Participate in error reduction and prevention processes

- i) Carry out distributive functions in a manner that minimizes medication errors and discrepancies
- ii) Collaborate with other healthcare professionals in reducing and preventing medication errors and discrepancies

E1.5 Perform appropriate audits on automated dispensing cabinet replenishment, packaging/repackaging of pharmaceutical products, bulk compounding products, and medication storage areas outside the dispensary

- i) Confirm that the:
 - Correct pharmaceutical product is being dispensed
 - Dosage and quantity of the pharmaceutical product being dispensed is correct
 - Pharmaceutical product is correctly labelled
- ii) Confirm that the appropriate signatures have been affixed and that documentation has been completed

E1.6 Participate in the development, implementation, and evaluation of quality indicators



COMPETENCY: COMMUNICATE WITH PATIENTS, PATIENTS' AGENTS, PHARMACISTS, AND HEALTHCARE PROVIDERS

Pharmacy technicians, as part of the pharmacy team, use their knowledge and skills and follow applicable policies and procedures to:

F1.0 COMPETENCY UNIT

Communicate within the role to support optimal patient care and pharmacy services.

COMPETENCY ELEMENTS

F1.1 Refer all therapeutic issues and questions to the pharmacist

F1.2 Establish and maintain positive working relationships with the patient, the patient's agent, members of the pharmacy team, and healthcare providers

- i) Display:
 - Respect, attentiveness, openness, empathy, and caring
 - Sensitivity to nonverbal communication
 - Sensitivity to diversity
- ii) Demonstrate appropriate and effective communication skills by:
 - Recognizing facilitators of, and challenges, to communication
 - Using oral and written language and communication style appropriate to purpose, setting, and situation
 - Using active listening, verbal and nonverbal communication skills including interviewing skills, and whenever appropriate, conflict resolution skills

F1.3 Maintain confidentiality of patient information

F1.4 Document demographic and prescription data, and other pharmacy related information in the patient profile or health record

- i) Follow standards, policies, and procedures related to documentation and to the maintenance, security, and disposal of records
- ii) Document clearly, concisely, correctly, and in a timely manner

F1.5 Use established communication policies, procedures, or protocols within the pharmacy, and when interacting with the patient, the patient's agent, and healthcare providers